

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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To the Bahá'ís of the World

191

31

10 July 2014

To the Bahá'ís of the World

Dearly loved Friends,

^{31.1} The setting of the sun on 20 March 2015 will signalize
the end of the year 171, the close of the ninth Váh .id of the
first Kull-i-Shay' of the Bahá'í Era. We call upon the Bahá'ís of
the East and West to adopt, on that auspicious occasion, the
provisions that will unite them in the common implementation
³² of the Badí' calendar.

^{31.2} In keeping with the principle governing the gradual
unfoldment and progressive application of the Teachings, the
³² provisions of the Badí' calendar have been set forth over time.

The Báb introduced the calendar and its broad pattern of peri-
ods and cycles, months and days. Bahá'u'lláh provided essential

³³ clarifications and additions. Aspects were elucidated by 'Abdu'l-Bahá, and
arrangements for its adoption in the West were put

in place at the direction of Shoghi Effendi, as described in the
volumes of The Bahá'í World. Still, ambiguities surrounding

some Islamic and Gregorian dates, as well as difficulties in the correlation of historical observances and astronomical events

with explicit statements in the Text, left certain issues unre-

34 solved. When responding to questions concerning the calendar,

clarification for the calendar's uniform application: the means

35 for the determination of Naw-Rúz, the accommodations of the lunar character of the Twin Holy Birthdays within the solar

year, and the fixing of the dates of the Holy Days within the

36 Badí' calendar.

31.3 "The Festival of Naw-Rúz falleth on the day that the sun

entereth the sign of Aries," Bahá'u'lláh explains in His Most

Holy Book, "even should this occur no more than one minute

before sunset." However, details have, until now, been left

32 192

33 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONundefined. We have decided that T .ihrán, the birthplace of the

Abhá Beauty, will be the spot on the earth that will serve as the

standard for determining, by means of astronomical computa-

tions from reliable sources, the moment of the vernal equinox

in the northern hemisphere and thereby the day of Naw-Rúz

34 for the Bahá'í world.

31.4 The Festivals of the Twin Birthdays, the Birth of the Báb

and the Birth of Bahá'u'lláh, have, in the East, been tradition-

ally observed according to their correspondence to the first and

second days of Muh .arram in the Islamic calendar. "These two

32 days are accounted as one in the sight of God," Bahá'u'lláh affirms. Yet, a letter written on behalf of the Guardian states,

"In the future, no doubt all of the Holy Days will follow the

Solar calendar, and provisions be made as to how the Twin

33 Festivals will be celebrated universally.” How to satisfy the intrinsic lunar character of these blessed Days within the

context of a solar calendar has hitherto been unanswered. We

have decided that they will now be observed on the first and the

second day following the occurrence of the eighth new moon

34 after Naw-Rúz, as determined in advance by astronomical tables using T .ihrán as the point of reference. This will result

35 in the observance of the Twin Birthdays moving, year to year, within the months of Mashíyyat, ‘Ilm, and Qudrat of the Badí’ calendar, or from mid-October to mid-November according

to the Gregorian calendar. Next year, the Birth of the Báb will

36 occur on 10 Qudrat and the Birth of Bahá’u’lláh on 11 Qudrat.

With joy and eager anticipation, we look to the upcoming

37 bicentennial anniversaries of the Birth of Bahá’u’lláh and the Birth of the Báb, in 174 and 176 B.E., respectively, which the

entire Bahá’í world will celebrate according to a common

38 calendar.

31.5 The dates of the remaining Holy Days will be fixed within

the solar calendar in accordance with explicit statements of

Bahá’u’lláh, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, and Shoghi Effendi; we have decided

to set aside certain discrepancies in the historical record. The

dates are: Naw-Rúz, 1 Bahá; the Festival of Rid .ván, 13 Jalál to

5 Jamál; the Declaration of the Báb, 8 ‘Az .amat; the Ascension

6 of Bahá’u’lláh, 13 ‘Az .amat; the Martyrdom of the Báb,

17 Rah .mat; the Day of the Covenant, 4 Qawl; and the

18 Ascension of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, 6 Qawl.

31.6 Unless specifically abrogated by these new provisions,

previous guidance and clarifications pertaining to the calendar

32 193

remain binding, such as the beginning of the day at sunset, the

suspension of work, and the hours at which certain Holy Days

are commemorated. In future, a change in circumstances may

33 well require additional measures.

31.7 It will be evident from the decisions delineated that Bahá'ís

of both East and West will find some elements of the calendar

32 to be different from those to which they have been accustomed.

The alignment of the dates of the Badí' calendar with other

33 calendars will shift depending on the occurrence of Naw-Rúz.

The number of days of Ayyám-i-Há will vary according to

34 the timing of the vernal equinox in successive years; the year commencing on Naw-Rúz 172 B.E. will include four such days.

A table prepared at the Bahá'í World Centre that sets out the

dates for Naw-Rúz and the Twin Holy Birthdays covering half

a century will be provided to all National Spiritual Assemblies

35 in due course.

31.8 The adoption of a new calendar in each dispensation is a

symbol of the power of Divine Revelation to reshape human

32 perception of material, social, and spiritual reality. Through it,

sacred moments are distinguished, humanity's place in time and

space reimagined, and the rhythm of life recast. Next Naw-Rúz

33 will mark yet another historic step in the manifestation of the unity of the people of Bahá and the unfoldment of Bahá'u'lláh's

34 World Order.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]